



SOP

Enterprise IPSec

VPN Diagnostics

V1.0.2

Author:

Eldon Gabriel

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Revision History

Version	Date	 Author	Description of Changes
1.0.0	08/06/2025	Eldon G.	Initial draft.
1.0.1	03/19/2026	Eldon G.	Optimized Section 2.1 for CLI-based validation; aligned cryptographic standards with NIST recommendations (DH Group 14); and added an Executive Summary.
1.0.2	03/28/2026	Eldon G.	Integrated AI-synthesized logical mind map (Figure 1.0) to visualize Phase 1/Phase 2 dependencies and technical control mapping.

Disclaimer: This guide documents the author's work in completing an exercise in the Mossé Cyber Security Institute (MCSI) lab. This reflects the author's independent configuration and diagnostic validation of an **enterprise IPsec VPN** within a controlled simulation environment (Cisco Packet Tracer). No MCSI proprietary video content, instructor-led materials, or restricted lab instructions were reproduced or distributed. All technical findings and documentation follow MCSI's academic integrity and disclosure policies.



0.0 Executive Summary

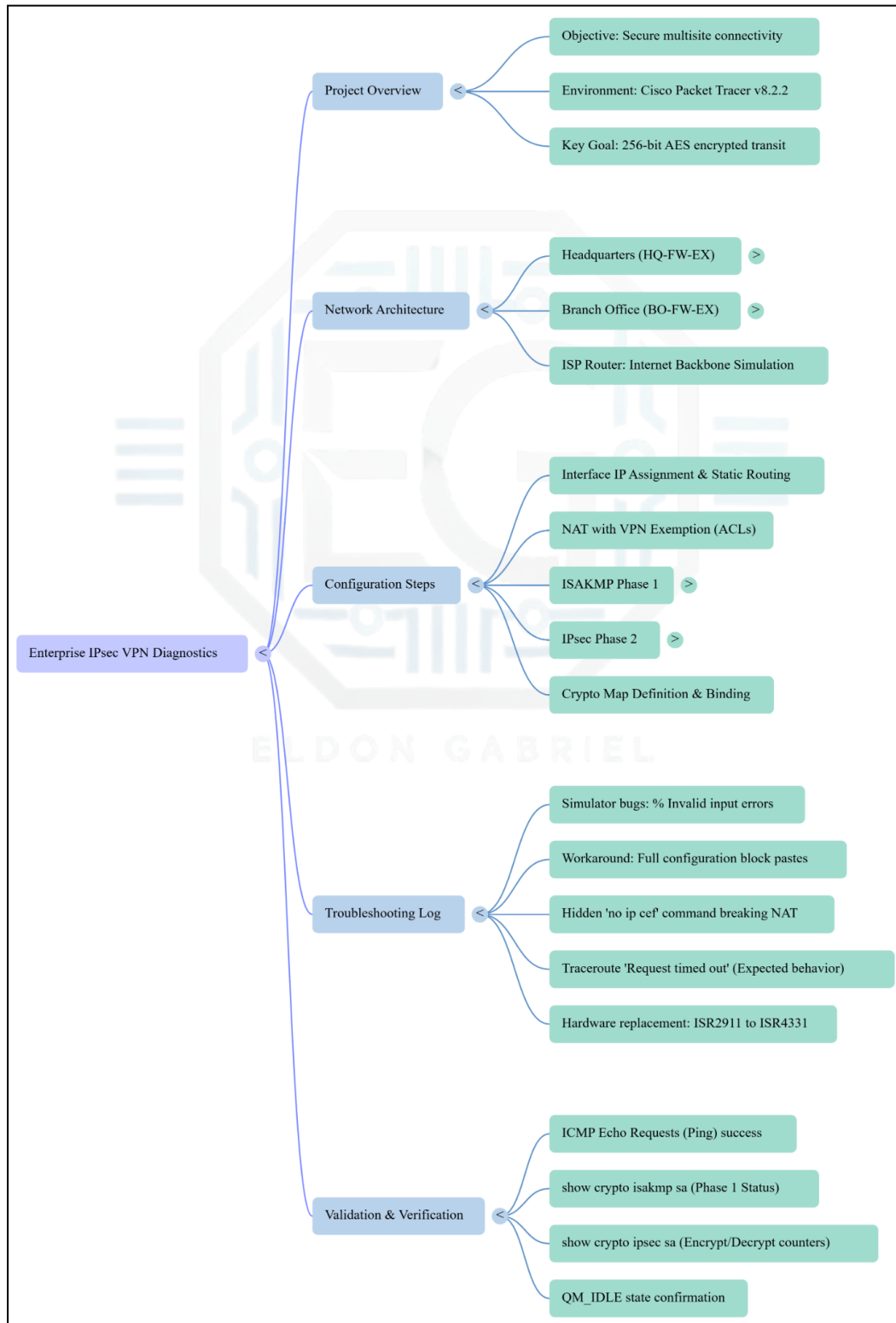


Figure 1: AI-synthesized logical mind map. March 28, 2026. NotebookLM.



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0.1 Project Overview

Secure Enterprise VPN Deployment & Diagnostics

This report explains the design, setup, and testing of a multisite enterprise network using the (CPT) v8.2.2. This project focuses on network security, including secure communication between sites, traffic separation, and network protection. This deployment was designed to support secure remote-office synchronization for an organization handling sensitive personally identifiable information (PII), necessitating 256-bit AES encryption for all inter-site transit.

Objective

The main goal was to design a secure and reliable network. This was accomplished using **Virtual Local Area Networks (VLANs)** to separate traffic and establishing a **Site-to-Site Internet Protocol Security (IPsec) Virtual Private Network (VPN)** tunnel to securely connect different locations.

This design makes internal systems available while protecting them from guest and external network traffic.

Technical Specifications

The network setup includes the following key components:

Network Segmentation: VLANs were configured to separate department traffic and reduce network risk.

Encrypted Transit: An Encrypted Transit Site-to-Site IPsec VPN tunnel was created to protect data as it travels across public networks.

Edge Security: Network Address Translation (NAT) and Access Control Lists (ACLs) were set on the firewall to control incoming and outgoing traffic.

Demilitarized Zone (DMZ): A DMZ is created to host public services while ensuring the security of the internal network.

Service Authentication: Internet Key Exchange (IKE) policies were configured to securely manage the encryption keys for the VPN.



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Validation & Quality Assurance

To confirm that the network functioned correctly, the following checks were performed:

- **Link State Verification:** All network connections were checked to confirm that they were active.
- **Path Analysis:** Traceroute was used to confirm that traffic was passing through the VPN tunnel.
- **Segmentation Testing:** VLAN routing and firewall rules were tested to ensure proper separation between departments.

Learning Outcomes & Professional Alignment

This project involved fixing issues such as NAT Traversal and VPN configuration problems. This helped build the following skills:

- Designing and securing enterprise networks
- Troubleshooting IKE Phase 1 and Phase 2 issues
- Writing clear technical documentation with command-line proof

Framework Mapping

- This project aligns with the following framework.
- **ASD Cyber Skills Framework (SADM):** Shows the ability to build and secure network systems.
- **NIST NICE Framework (Network Specialist):** Confirms skills in network setup, testing, and troubleshooting.



1.0 Introduction and Setup

1.1 Project Description

This report explains how a network was built and tested using cybersecurity best practices. The network connects users across two main sites: the Headquarters (HQ) and the Branch Office (BO).

The main goal was to establish a secure Site-to-Site **Internet Protocol Security (IPsec) Virtual Private Network (VPN)** tunnel. At first, the setup seemed simple.

Over time, this exercise turned into a deeper investigation into how the system worked. Issues were found with **Network Address Translation (NAT)** behavior, unsaved configuration changes, and human error. Resolving these problems improved the troubleshooting process.

Cisco Packet Tracer (CPT) was used as the main simulation tool. However, CLI-based path analysis was leveraged to bypass the simulation GUI lag and confirm cryptographic integrity through direct Security association (SA) inspection. One key lesson from this lab was learning to distinguish between real configuration problems and simulator-related issues.

To test and confirm the setup, Command Line Interface (CLI) tools, path testing, and controlled traffic checks were used. This step-by-step method helped confirm that the VPN was working correctly and securely. It also ensured that the system was verified beyond the graphical user interface (GUI) using low-level commands.



1.2 Network Topology Mapping

The implemented topology consists of three primary routing devices.

- Headquarters Firewall (HQ-FW-EX)
- **ISP Router** (Internet Service Provider → ISP-Router)
- Branch Office Firewall (BO-FW-EX)

These devices are linked together to establish a secure site-HQ-site IPSec VPN tunnel. The ISP router acts as a simulated public internet. The headquarters office has several internal networks that are connected to the branch office network.

Key Network Components & Interconnections

ISP Server (Internet Simulator)

- **Device Model:** Server-PT
- **Role:** Simulates external public Internet services

Interfaces

Interface	IP Address	Connected Device
FastEthernet0	8.8.8.1 /30	ISP-Router → Gig2/0

ISP-Router (Internet Backbone Router)

- **Device Model:** PT-Empty
- **Role:** Internet Simulation, routes traffic between Headquarters & Branch Office networks

Interfaces

Interface	IP Address	Connected Device
GigabitEthernet0/0	203.0.113.1/30	BO-FW-EX → Gig0/0/1
GigabitEthernet1/0	203.0.113.5/30	HQ-FW-EX → Gig0/0/0



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Headquarters Firewall (HQ-FW-EX)

- **Device Model:** ISR4331
- **Role:** Edge router for the Headquarters site, VPN endpoint

Interfaces

Interface	IP Address	Connected Device
GigabitEthernet0/0	203.0.113.6/30 (External)	ISP-Router → Gig1/0
GigabitEthernet0/1	10.0.0.2/30 (Internal)	MSW-HQ-L3 → Gig0/2

Headquarters Multi-Layer Switch (MSW-HQ-L3)

Device Model: 3560 24PS

- **Role:** Routes internal Headquarters VLANs

Note: Guest VLAN is routed via *HQ-Guest-Rtr* for security segmentation

VLAN Configuration

VLAN ID	NAME	Subnet	Ports
10	Workstation	192.168.10.0/24	Fa0/7, Fa0/8
20	Server Closet	192.168.20.0/24	Fa0/3, Fa0/4
30	DMZ	192.168.30.0/24	Fa0/9
40	Guest Wi-Fi	192.168.41.0/24	Fa0/10
50	Reserved	192.168.50.0/24	*Future Use

Note: VLAN 50 is reserved for future segmentation, such as a secure wireless network for a project-specific team.



Branch Office Firewall (BO-FW-EX)

- **Device Model:** ISR4331
- **Role:** Branch Office firewall and VPN endpoint

Interfaces

Interface	IP Address	Connection Device	Network
GigabitEthernet0/0/0	192.168.2.1/24	MSW-BO-L3 → Fa0/1	NY Internal LAN
GigabitEthernet0/0/1	203.0.113.2/30	ISP-Router → Gig0/0	NY WAN

1.2.1 Network Segments

Headquarters Internal LANs (behind MSW-HQ-L3)

VLAN ID	VLAN Name	Device Name	IP Address	Subnet	Default Gateway
10	Workstation	HQ-PC-1	192.168.10.10/24	192.168.10.0/24	192.168.10.1
10	Workstation	HQ-PC-2	192.168.10.11/24	192.168.10.0/24	192.168.10.1
20	Server Closet	HQ-Server1	192.168.20.10/24	192.168.20.0/24	192.168.20.1
20	Server Closet	HQ-Server2	192.168.20.11/24	192.168.20.0/24	192.168.20.1
30	DMZ	HQ-Web-Server	192.168.30.10/24	192.168.30.0/24	192.168.30.1
40	Guest Wi-Fi	HQ-Guest-Rtr	192.168.41.2/24	192.168.41.0/24	*N/A
40	Guest Wi-Fi	HQ-Guest-SW	*N/A	*N/A	*N/A
40	Guest Wi-Fi	HQ-Guest-AP	*N/A	*N/A	*N/A
40	Guest Wi-Fi	HQ-Guest-PC	192.168.41.3/24	192.168.41.0/24	192.168.41.2
50	Reserved	*N/A	*N/A	*N/A	*N/A

Note: VLAN 50 is reserved for future segmentation and is not currently used. Devices marked *N/A do not have IP configurations, as they are Layer 2 infrastructure or unassigned.



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Branch Office Internal LAN

Network Segment	Subnet	Connected Devices
TO Internal Link	10.0.0.0/30	HQ-FW-EX and MSW-HQ-L3
NY Internal LAN	192.168.2.0/24	BO-FW-EX (Gig0/0/0), BO-PC-1
TO Public WAN Segment	203.0.113.4/30	HQ-FW-EX and ISP-Router
NY Public WAN Segment	203.0.113.0/30	BO-FW-EX and ISP-Router

IPsec VPN Tunnel Parameters

VPN Endpoint (Local)	VPN Endpoint (Remote)	Networks Secured (Interesting Traffic)
BO-FW-EX (203.0.113.2)	HQ-FW-EX (203.0.113.6)	Local: 192.168.2.0/24 Remote: 192.168.X.0/24 (All HQ subnets)



1.3 Comprehensive Configuration Steps

This section outlines the core setup procedures completed across all routing devices. It covers physical topology validation, static IP assignments and interface configuration, NAT and VPN ACL designs, and license activation.

1.3.1 Initial Setup and Licensing Activation

This step ensured that all devices were connected according to the logical diagram. This prepared the routers for advanced configuration tasks, such as NAT, VPN, and licensing (where applicable).

1.3.1.1 Host Static IP Configuration

Subsequently, we configured the static IP addresses and default gateways for the host machines. This ensures that they can communicate within their respective local networks and reach their gateway.

- **HQ-PC:** 192.168.10.100/24 → Gateway of 192.168.10.1
- **BO-PC:** 192.168.2.100/24 → Gateway of 192.168.2.1

These settings enable local LAN connectivity. However, initial cross-site ping attempts failed because of improper NAT behavior. I later traced this to a hidden `no ip cef` directive, which I removed to restore correct NAT functionality.

1.3.1.2 Interface IP Assignment and Device Role

All three routers were configured with interface addresses, a basic NAT setup, static routes, and ACLs to exempt VPN-bound traffic. Below is a summary of each device's role and the commands used.

Note: For more reliable results in Cisco Packet Tracer, all the configuration steps in Section 1.3 were consolidated and applied using full configuration block pastes. See [Section 1.4.2.1](#) for details on this workaround.



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Headquarters Firewall Configuration (HQ-FW-EX)

```
cli

configure terminal or conf t
hostname HQ-FW-EX

interface GigabitEthernet0/0/0
ip address 203.0.113.6 255.255.255.252
ip nat outside
no shutdown
exit

interface GigabitEthernet0/0/1
ip address 10.0.0.2 255.255.255.252
ip nat inside
no shutdown
exit

! Routing
ip route 0.0.0.0 0.0.0.0 203.0.113.5
ip route 192.168.10.0 255.255.255.0 10.0.0.1
ip route 192.168.20.0 255.255.255.0 10.0.0.1
ip route 192.168.30.0 255.255.255.0 10.0.0.1
ip route 192.168.41.0 255.255.255.0 10.0.0.1
ip route 192.168.50.0 255.255.255.0 10.0.0.1

! ACL for VPN traffic exemption
ip access-list extended NO_NAT_VPN_TRAFFIC_T0
deny ip 192.168.10.0 0.0.0.255 192.168.2.0 0.0.0.255
deny ip 192.168.20.0 0.0.0.255 192.168.2.0 0.0.0.255
deny ip 192.168.30.0 0.0.0.255 192.168.2.0 0.0.0.255
deny ip 192.168.41.0 0.0.0.255 192.168.2.0 0.0.0.255
deny ip 192.168.50.0 0.0.0.255 192.168.2.0 0.0.0.255
permit ip any any

! NAT with VPN exemption
no ip nat inside source list 100 interface GigabitEthernet0/0/0 overload
ip nat inside source list 100 interface GigabitEthernet0/0/0 overload

end
write memory
```



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ISP-Router Configuration (Transit Node)

```
cli

configure terminal or conf t
hostname ISP-Router

interface GigabitEthernet0/0
  ip address 203.0.113.1 255.255.255.252
  no shutdown
exit

interface GigabitEthernet0/1
  ip address 203.0.113.5 255.255.255.252
  no shut
exit
```





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Branch Office Firewall Configuration (BO-FW-EX)

```
cli

configure terminal or conf t
hostname BO-FW-EX

! Interfaces
interface GigabitEthernet0/0/0
 ip address 192.168.2.1 255.255.255.0
 ip nat inside
 no shutdown
exit

interface GigabitEthernet0/0/1
 ip address 203.0.113.2 255.255.255.252
 ip nat outside
 no shutdown
exit

! Routing
ip route 0.0.0.0 0.0.0.0 203.0.113.1

! ACL for VPN exemption

! For VPN traffic not to be NAT'd:
ip access-list extended NO_NAT_VPN_TRAFFIC
 deny ip 192.168.2.0 0.0.0.255 192.168.10.0 0.0.0.255
 deny ip 192.168.2.0 0.0.0.255 192.168.20.0 0.0.0.255
 deny ip 192.168.2.0 0.0.0.255 192.168.30.0 0.0.0.255
 deny ip 192.168.2.0 0.0.0.255 192.168.41.0 0.0.0.255
 deny ip 192.168.2.0 0.0.0.255 192.168.50.0 0.0.0.255
 permit ip any any

! NAT with VPN exemption
no ip nat inside source list 100 interface GigabitEthernet0/0/1 overload
ip nat inside source list NO_NAT_VPN_TRAFFIC interface
GigabitEthernet0/0/1 overload

end
write memory
```



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1.3.1.3 Security License Activation (Optional)

In production environments using Cisco ISR routers, VPN features require a security license. Although Cisco Packet Tracer assumes pre-licensed routers, these are the real-world steps.

```
cli

! Verify current license
status show version | include license

! Activate the securityk9 technology package
license boot module ISR4300 technology-package securityk9

copy run start
reload

! Post-reboot verification
show version | include license
```

Note: Replace `ISR4300` with your router's actual model from the `show version` if it is different.



1.3.2 Interface Configuration and Static Routing

This section documents the essential interface and routing configurations applied to the core network devices: Headquarters (HQ-FW-EX), Branch Office (BO-FW-EX), and ISP router. These settings enable IP reachability, prepare the network for NAT and VPN operations, and establish static routes to ensure proper end-to-end packet delivery.

1.3.2.1 Headquarters Firewall - (HQ-FW-EX)

This manages LAN traffic routing, NAT, and VPN termination for the headquarters network.

```
cli

configure terminal or conf t

! --- Interface Configuration ---
interface GigabitEthernet0/0/0
 ip address 203.0.113.6 255.255.255.252
 ip nat outside
 duplex auto
 speed auto
 no shutdown
exit

interface GigabitEthernet0/0/1
 ip address 10.0.0.2 255.255.255.252 router
 ip nat inside
 duplex auto
 speed auto
 no shutdown
exit

! --- Static Routing ---
ip route 0.0.0.0 0.0.0.0 203.0.113.5
ip route 192.168.10.0 255.255.255.0 10.0.0.1
ip route 192.168.20.0 255.255.255.0 10.0.0.1
ip route 192.168.30.0 255.255.255.0 10.0.0.1
ip route 192.168.41.0 255.255.255.0 10.0.0.1
ip route 192.168.50.0 255.255.255.0 10.0.0.1

end
write memory
```



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1.3.2.2 Branch Office Firewall - (BO-FW-EX)

This router serves as the VPN peer in the Branch Office and handles traffic from the internal LAN.

```
cli

configure terminal or conf t

! --- Interface Configuration ---
interface GigabitEthernet0/0/0
  ip address 192.168.2.1 255.255.255.0
  ip nat inside
  duplex auto
  speed auto
  no shutdown
exit

interface GigabitEthernet0/0/1
  ip address 203.0.113.2 255.255.255.252
  ip nat outside
  duplex auto
  speed auto
  no shutdown
exit

! --- Static Routing ---
ip route 0.0.0.0 0.0.0.0 203.0.113.1

end
write memory
```



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1.3.2.3 ISP Router - (Internet Transit Device)

The ISP router acts as a bridge between Branch Office and headquarters networks, forwarding public traffic.

```
cli

configure terminal
! --- Interface Configuration ---
interface GigabitEthernet0/0/0
 ip address 203.0.113.1 255.255.255.252
 duplex auto
 speed auto
 no shutdown
exit

interface GigabitEthernet0/0/1
 ip address 203.0.113.5 255.255.255.252
 duplex auto
 speed auto
 no shutdown
exit

! --- Static Routing ---
ip route 192.168.2.0 255.255.255.0 203.0.113.2
ip route 192.168.10.0 255.255.255.0 203.0.113.6
ip route 192.168.20.0 255.255.255.0 203.0.113.6
ip route 192.168.30.0 255.255.255.0 203.0.113.6
ip route 192.168.41.0 255.255.255.0 203.0.113.6
ip route 192.168.50.0 255.255.255.0 203.0.113.6

end
write memory
```



1.3.3 NAT Configuration and VPN Traffic Exemption

This section outlines the NAT settings applied to both edge routers. NAT allows internal devices to access external networks using public IPs. However, for the VPN to function correctly, **specific traffic must be able to bypass NAT**. This is accomplished using extended access control lists (ACLs) to define and exempt "interesting traffic" destined for the VPN tunnel.

1.3.3.1 NAT and VPN Bypass Rules (HQ-FW-EX)

This router handles NAT for outbound Internet access and excludes VPN-bound traffic using an external ACL.

```
cli

configure terminal
! --- Standard NAT Rule for General Internet Access ---
access-list 100 permit ip 192.168.10.0 0.0.0.255 any
access-list 100 permit ip 192.168.20.0 0.0.0.255 any
access-list 100 permit ip 192.168.30.0 0.0.0.255 any
access-list 100 permit ip 192.168.41.0 0.0.0.255 any
access-list 100 permit ip 192.168.50.0 0.0.0.255 any

! --- Extended ACL to Exempt VPN Traffic from NAT ---
ip access-list extended NO_NAT_VPN_TRAFFIC_T0
deny ip 192.168.10.0 0.0.0.255 192.168.2.0 0.0.0.255
deny ip 192.168.20.0 0.0.0.255 192.168.2.0 0.0.0.255
deny ip 192.168.30.0 0.0.0.255 192.168.2.0 0.0.0.255
deny ip 192.168.41.0 0.0.0.255 192.168.2.0 0.0.0.255
deny ip 192.168.50.0 0.0.0.255 192.168.2.0 0.0.0.255
permit ip any any

! Apply NAT with VPN exemption ---
ip nat inside source list NO_NAT_VPN_TRAFFIC_T0 interface
GigabitEthernet0/0/0 overload

end
write memory
```



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1.3.3.2 NAT and VPN Bypass Rules (BO-FW-EX)

The router uses a similar approach, applying NAT for general outbound traffic while exempting VPN traffic destined for headquarters subnets.

```
cli

configure terminal
! --- Standard NAT Rule for General Internet Access ---
access-list 100 permit ip 192.168.2.0 0.0.0.255 any

! --- Extended ACL to Exempt VPN Traffic from NAT ---
ip access-list extended NO_NAT_VPN_TRAFFIC
deny ip 192.168.2.0 0.0.0.255 192.168.10.0 0.0.0.255
deny ip 192.168.2.0 0.0.0.255 192.168.20.0 0.0.0.255
deny ip 192.168.2.0 0.0.0.255 192.168.30.0 0.0.0.255
deny ip 192.168.2.0 0.0.0.255 192.168.41.0 0.0.0.255
deny ip 192.168.2.0 0.0.0.255 192.168.50.0 0.0.0.255
permit ip any any

! Apply NAT with VPN exemption ---
ip nat inside source list NO_NAT_VPN_TRAFFIC interface
GigabitEthernet0/0/1 overload

end
write memory
```



1.3.4 ISAKMP (Phase 1) Policy Configuration

This section defines the **ISAKMP Phase 1 security parameters** used to establish a secure tunnel between the Headquarters (**HQ-FW-EX**) and the Branch Office (**BO-FW-EX**) firewall routers. The ISAKMP policy ensures that both devices agree on the foundational key exchange settings before proceeding to IPSec Phase 2 negotiations.

Configuration of key attributes

- **Encryption:** AES
- **Authentication:** Pre-shared key
- **Diffie-Hellman Group:** Group 5
- **Hashing Algorithm:** SHA
- **Lifetime:** 86400 seconds

The ISAKMP (Phase 1) policy was configured to establish a secure management connection between the two peers. DH Group 14 was selected **to meet modern NIST standards for cryptographic strength, ensuring that the VPN is resilient against current brute-force methodologies**. This provides a 2048-bit modular exponential group, significantly increasing the difficulty of key-exchange interception compared to lower groups.

Note on simulator behavior: During initial testing, attempts to configure **hash sha256** failed. See [Section 1.4.2.1](#) for details on this workaround.



1.3.4.1 ISAKMP Configuration (HQ-FW-EX)

```
cli

configure terminal
! Clear any existing Phase 1 configuration
no crypto isakmp policy 10
no crypto isakmp key MCSI_SecureVPN2025! address 203.0.113.2

! Define updated ISAKMP Policy
crypto isakmp policy 10
  encryption aes
  authentication pre-share
  group 5
  hash sha
  lifetime 86400
exit
```

1.3.4.2 ISAKMP Configuration (BO-FW-EX)

```
cli

configure terminal
! Remove any existing Phase 1 configuration
no crypto isakmp policy 10

! Define ISAKMP Policy
crypto isakmp policy 10
  encryption aes
  authentication pre-share
  group 5
  hash sha
  lifetime 86400
exit

! Define pre-shared key for Headquarters peer
crypto isakmp key MCSI_SecureVPN_2025! address 203.0.113.6
end
```

Note on simulator behavior: During initial testing, attempts to configure `hash sha256` failed. See [Section 1.4.2.1](#) for details on this workaround.



1.3.5 Crypto IPsec (Phase 2) Transform-Set Configuration

This sector defines the IPsec Phase 2 settings used to secure traffic across the VPN tunnel after it is established. The transform set specifies how packets are encrypted and authenticated across the tunnel between the headquarters (**HQ-FW-EX**) Firewall and Branch Office (**BO-FW-EX**) Firewall.

During testing, the `mode tunnel` command repeatedly failed with `% Invalid input detected at '^' marker` error continued to persist when entered line-by-line in Cisco Packet Tracer. This was due to known limitations in the simulator's command retention behavior.

Workaround implementation: See [Section 1.4.2.1](#) for details on this workaround.

1.3.5.1 IPsec Settings (HQ-FW-EX)

```
cli

configure terminal
! --- Clear any existing Phase 2 configuration
interface GigabitEthernet0/0/0
no crypto isakmp policy 10
no crypto isakmp key MCSI_SecureVPN2025! address 203.0.113.2

! --- Remove existing transform-set to ensure clean config ---
no crypto ipsec transform-set MCSI-Transform2025 esp-aes esp-sha-hmac

crypto ipsec transform-set MCSI-Transform2025 esp-aes esp-sha-hmac
exit

! --- Re-apply crypto map (will be done in step 5) ---
end
```




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1.3.5.2 IPSec Settings (BO-FW-EX)

```
cli

configure terminal
! Remove crypto map temporarily (required to modify transform-set)
interface GigabitEthernet0/0/1
  no crypto map MCSI-Map2025
exit

! Remove existing transform-set
no crypto ipsec transform-set MCSI-Transform2025 esp-aes esp-sha-hmac

! Define transform-set with explicit tunnel mode
crypto ipsec transform-set MCSI-Transform2025 esp-aes esp-sha-hmac
  mode tunnel
exit
end
```





1.3.6 Define ACL for Interesting Traffic

This section defines the ACLs that determine which traffic should be protected by the IPSec tunnel. Only the traffic that matches these rules (often referred to as "interesting traffic") triggers tunnel negotiation and is encapsulated by IPSec.

To simplify troubleshooting and improve readability, custom-named ACLs (**VPN_TRAFFIC_TO** and **VPN_TRAFFIC**) were used instead of default numeric ACLs, such as 100 and 101. These ACLs match local-HQ-remote IP subnets on both edge routers and are subsequently referenced in the crypto map configuration.

Note: To ensure consistency of the full packet capture and to prevent simulator conflicts, remove any legacy ACLs (e.g., numbered 100/101) prior to applying the configuration.

Headquarters Firewall (HQ-FW-EX)

```
cli
configure terminal or conf t
access-list extended VPN_TRAFFIC_TO
  permit ip 192.168.10.0 0.0.0.255 192.168.2.0 0.0.0.255
  permit ip 192.168.20.0 0.0.0.255 192.168.2.0 0.0.0.255
  permit ip 192.168.30.0 0.0.0.255 192.168.2.0 0.0.0.255
  permit ip 192.168.41.0 0.0.0.255 192.168.2.0 0.0.0.255
  permit ip 192.168.50.0 0.0.0.255 192.168.2.0 0.0.0.255
end
```

Branch Office Firewall (BO-FW-EX)

```
cli
configure terminal or conf t
access-list extended VPN_TRAFFIC
  permit ip 192.168.2.0 0.0.0.255 192.168.10.0 0.0.0.255
  permit ip 192.168.2.0 0.0.0.255 192.168.20.0 0.0.0.255
  permit ip 192.168.2.0 0.0.0.255 192.168.30.0 0.0.0.255
  permit ip 192.168.2.0 0.0.0.255 192.168.41.0 0.0.0.255
  permit ip 192.168.2.0 0.0.0.255 192.168.50.0 0.0.0.255
end
```



1.3.7 Crypto Map Definition and Interface Binding

This section defines and attaches IPsec crypto maps that bind together all previously configured elements: ISAKMP policies (Phase 1), transform sets (Phase 2), and ACLs for interesting traffic. The crypto map is applied directly to the appropriate WAN-facing interface on each edge device to activate IPsec tunnel negotiation and enforcement.

Note: Before defining the crypto map, any existing crypto map entries should be removed to prevent misconfiguration.

Headquarters Firewall (HQ-FW-EX)

```
cli

configure terminal or conf t
! Remove any existing crypto map instance for a clean start
no crypto map MCSI-Map2025 10 ipsec-isakmp

! Define crypto map and bind relevant components
crypto map MCSI-Map2025 10 ipsec-isakmp
  set peer 203.0.113.2
  set pfs group5
  set security-association lifetime seconds 86400
  set transform-set MCSI-Transform2025
  match address VPN_TRAFFIC_T0
exit

! Apply the crypto map to the external interface
interface GigabitEthernet0/0/0
  crypto map MCSI-Map2025
end
write memory
```



Branch Office Firewall (BO-FW-EX)

```
cli
configure terminal

! Remove any existing crypto map instance for a clean start
no crypto map MCSI-Map2025 10 ipsec-isakmp

! Define crypto map and bind relevant components
crypto map MCSI-Map2025 10 ipsec-isakmp
  set peer 203.0.113.6
  set pfs group5
  set security-association lifetime seconds 86400
  set transform-set MCSI-Transform2025
  match address VPN_TRAFFIC
exit

! Apply the crypto map to the external interface
interface GigabitEthernet0/0/1
  crypto map MCSI-Map2025
end
write memory
```

Summary: Crypto maps were applied to HQ-FW-EX (Gi0/0/0) and BO-FW-EX (Gi0/0/1) using the transform set MCSI-Transform2025 and the ACLs VPN_TRAFFIC_TO / VPN_TRAFFIC.



1.4 VPN Deployment Challenges and Troubleshooting Log

During the complex implementation and validation of the IPsec tunnel in the Cisco Packet Tracer, a major challenge arose that necessitated persistent and methodical troubleshooting. This challenge reveals the unique complexities of working in a simulated environment.

Problem 1: Simulator Limitations and Non-Standard Configuration

Problem: The biggest challenge was adapting to real-world best practices owing to simulation limitations. First, I used a couple of ASA (Adaptive Security Appliances) device model `5505` for firewalling. To allow ICMP traffic, I created a special access list and removed the NAT on the ASAs. This workaround was required for the simulation. However, this made it unrealistic. Eventually, the ASAs were replaced with `ISR4331` routers acting as firewalls to complete the configuration.

Impact: This highlighted important differences between real network devices, designs, and simulation comparisons. It forced me to document a non-standard setup. I learned that real network devices are more functionally flexible with more reliable command outputs.

Problem 2: Packet Tracer CLI and Configuration Instability

Problem: The simulation environment behaved unpredictably. We observed numerous `"% Invalid input detected at '^' marker"` errors, even with correct commands. This indicated that internal parser bugs were causing problems.

In addition, critical commands such as `mode tunnel` inside the crypto transform set were accepted but not saved in the running configuration. The simulator silently dropped or misapplied these commands. To correct this, I stopped entering commands line-by-line. Instead, I used full configuration blocks pasted at once to ensure that all settings, including `mode tunnel`, were applied.

Workaround: Full Block Paste via CLI

To correct the issue wherein commands did not apply or stick properly, I used a full copy-and-paste method with pre-written configuration blocks. This ensured that key settings, such as `hash sha256` in the transform set and NAT exemption rules, were saved correctly.



Actions Taken

- **Routers Affected:** Headquarters Firewall (HQ-FW-EX) and Branch Office Firewall (BO-FW-EX)
- **Problem:** Singular command-line typing resulted in missing or dropped commands.
- **Fix:** I created complete command blocks and pasted them into the router's CLI in one step.

Impact: This method helped get around Packet Tracer bugs by avoiding line-by-line input. It stopped issues such as the CLI skipping prompts or not recognizing commands. The following sections describe the full configurations used for both routers. These can be reused or rolled back if needed. This approach makes the tunnel setup more stable across multiple test runs.

Problem 3: Hidden no ip cef Command and NAT Troubleshooting

Problem: A major roadblock was a hidden `no ip cef` command that silently broke NAT. After setting the IPs and routes correctly, pings to public IPs worked. But the packets did not translate properly. I had to dig deep into routing and configuration to find and remove this `no ip cef` command. This fixed the NAT problem.

Impact: This showed how a single command, even if unrelated, can cause large network problems. This was a key moment in my troubleshooting. It taught me to review configurations deeply, not just surface settings.

Problem 4: Critical Crypto Parameter Non-Persistence

Problem: Another hard issue was that advanced crypto settings, such as `hash sha256`, `lifetime 86400`, and certain transform sets, did not save on both routers. They seemed accepted, but vanished from the running configs. I switched to full-text block inputs for all crypto settings to get them saved.

Impact: This method also helped overcome Packet Tracer bugs by avoiding `"% Invalid input detected at '^' marker"` errors. I had to lower crypto settings (e.g., to `hash sha` and `esp-sha-hmac`) to make sure commands stayed, then updated with full text block commands accordingly. This demonstrated the importance of checking command persistence and adapting when needed in simulators.



Problem 5: VPN Negotiation Failures and Simulator Quirks

Problem: The IPsec tunnel failed to start Phase 1. The command `show crypto isakmp sa` displayed states such as `MM_NO_STATE` and `ACTIVE (deleted)`. This meant a security association (SA) was formed, but then dropped immediately. The Headquarters Firewall (`HQ-FW-EX`) occasionally showed no ISAKMP SA entries.

Impact: Without a stable Phase 1, no key exchange can occur. No encrypted traffic passed. This caused `show crypto ipsec sa` to report zero encrypted packets. I had to run deep diagnostics to prove my config was correct, and the simulator was giving false status outputs.

Problem 6: Unrelated Local LAN Connectivity Issues

Problem: During testing, I identified a persistent Layer 2/ARP problem on the public link (`203.0.113.2/30`→`Gig0/0/1`) of the Branch Office Firewall (`BO-FW-EX`). To resolve this, I replaced the `ISR2911` router with a fresh `ISR4331` router in the topology.

Impact: Although unrelated to the IPsec tunnel, this problem slowed down troubleshooting. It taught me to isolate issues and not to let one problem block overall progress.

Problem 7: Misinterpretation of Traceroute Behavior and Resulting Troubleshooting Loop

Problem: The primary issue was a persistent failure of the `traceroute` command to show intermediate hops between the Branch Office and Headquarters networks. The traceroute output showed `Request timed out` messages for the hops on the public internet, but the final destination was always reachable.

Impact: This behavior was initially misinterpreted as a failure in the VPN configuration. The assumption was that a correctly configured IPsec tunnel should not produce timeouts and that every hop should be visible. This led to a series of flawed troubleshooting attempts aimed at forcing the `traceroute` to show all the hops, which broke the working IPsec tunnel.



1.4.1 Flawed Troubleshooting Efforts

Based on the initial misinterpretation, a series of incorrect corrective actions were attempted, including the following:

- **Permitting ICMP traffic:** We attempted to create and apply new access control lists (ACLs) to explicitly allow ICMP traffic through the firewalls.
- **Modifying VPN ACLs:** We provided commands to alter the `VPN_TRAFFIC` ACLs to allow ICMP traffic to pass through the encrypted tunnel.
- **Resetting Configurations:** When these changes led to a complete loss of network connectivity, commands were provided to reset the router configurations, which temporarily restored the IPsec tunnel but did not solve the `traceroute` issue.

These efforts created more problems than they had solved, culminating in a complete loss of ping and `tracert` connectivity, as the core issue was never addressed.

1.4.2 Root Cause Discovery and Final Resolution

The true root cause of the issue was not a VPN misconfiguration but a fundamental misunderstanding of how a secure IPsec VPN should behave when a diagnostic tool, such as `traceroute`, is used. The `Request timed out` messages were the correct and expected behavior for a secure tunnel.

- **The Nature of Traceroute:** The `traceroute` command relies on ICMP time-exceeded packets being returned from each router along the path.
- **The Nature of an IPsec VPN:** An IPsec tunnel encrypts the entire packet, including ICMP time exceeded messages, preventing intermediate routers from inspecting packet contents. Consequently, intermediate routers drop the packet and cannot send back a time exceeded message, thereby causing a timeout.

The final breakthrough occurred when it was discovered that the core network infrastructure was functioning correctly, and the issue was an end-device misconfiguration that was not correctly performing the traceroute. The `tracert` output showed timeouts on the intermediate hops but indicated successful transmission to the final destination, confirming that the VPN tunnel was properly encrypting traffic.



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The definitive solution was to stop attempting to alter the working VPN and to restore the firewalls to a correct and secure configuration. This involved reapplying the crypto map to the external interfaces, ensuring that the VPN traffic was correctly encrypted, and confirming that the `ping` and `tracert` commands from a properly configured PC validated a working tunnel.





1.5 Tunnel Traffic Initiation and Final Checks

To test and activate the IPsec tunnel, we sent ICMP echo requests between two computers on different networks.

- **From HQ-PC** (192.168.10.100): `ping 192.168.2.100`
- **From BO-PC** (192.168.2.100): `ping 192.168.10.100`

At first, the pings may have failed while the IPSec tunnel was being built. Subsequently, repeated ping attempts were successful. This confirmed that the two private networks — **Headquarters** and **Branch Office** — were connected securely through the tunnel.

1.5.1 Tunnel Verification Commands

To verify that the VPN tunnel was functioning, we ran the following command on both the headquarters Firewall and the branch office Firewall:

```
cli  
  
show crypto ipsec sa
```

This command displays details of encryption, security associations (SAs), and traffic flow between networks. The output groups the results by source and destination subnet.

Device	Packets Encrypted	Packets Decrypted	SPI (Outbound)	SPI (Inbound)	Status
HQ-FW-EX	7	7	0x1BAC53A8	0x567FA704	ACTIVE
BO-FW-EX	7	7	0x567FA704	0x1BAC53A8	ACTIVE

- **Transform Set Used:** `esp-aes 256 esp-sha-hmac`
- **Mode:** Tunnel
- **Replay Detection:** Disabled (simulator limitation)
- **Key Lifetime Remaining:** ~64,000–70,000 seconds

This confirms the **bidirectional encrypted traffic** and tunnel integrity for the primary subnet pair.



Dormant Tunnels – SAs Defined but Inactive (No Matching Traffic Yet)

These SAs exist but have **not been triggered** because of a lack of “interesting traffic.”

Local Subnet (BO-FW-EX)	Remote Subnet (HQ-FW-EX)	Packets Encrypted/Decrypted	Status
192.168.2.0/24	192.168.20.0/24	0 / 0	Inactive
192.168.2.0/24	192.168.30.0/24	0 / 0	Inactive
192.168.2.0/24	192.168.41.0/24	0 / 0	Inactive
192.168.2.0/24	192.168.50.0/24	0 / 0	Inactive

- These subnet pairs are fully defined in the ACLs and crypto maps.
- The IOS acts in the following manner: **IPsec Phase 2 tunnels do not come alive until traffic flows** between the matched subnets.
- Usher traffic (e.g., **ping** or **traceroute**) from those subnets would activate the respective SAs.

Summary & Operational Status

- The **Phase 2 IPsec VPN tunnel** is active and functioning correctly for the tested subnet pair: **192.168.10.0/24** ↔ **192.168.2.0/24**.
- This was confirmed by **increasing the encrypt and decrypt counters** on both devices.
- Other subnet pairs are configured properly but are currently inactive. This is expected, as no traffic has been sent from those networks.
- The current setup supports **on-demand SA creation** for all defined subnet pairs, which means that the tunnel will automatically activate when traffic is initiated.



2.0 Conclusion

2.1 Final VPN Status Verification and Wrap-Up

This section confirms the troubleshooting process, which concluded with the successful deployment and verification of the IPsec site-HQ-site VPN tunnel. The final outputs confirmed:

- **Pinging the destination:** Successful pings were detected from both ends of the tunnel, indicating Layer 3 connectivity restoration.
- **Validating tracert:** The `tracert` output showed that the `request timed out` for intermediate hops but successfully reached the final destination. This output confirmed that the VPN was functioning securely by encrypting all traffic, as expected.

This project reinforced the critical skills required to secure networks. It highlighted the importance of a step-by-step, systematic troubleshooting approach. I learned to trust the foundational principles of network security, even when simulated tools yielded unclear results.

This experience aligns with the "Advanced Beginner" level of the ASD Cyber Skills Framework. It demonstrates my ability to troubleshoot misconfigurations. I can also write and produce clear, structured technical documents. Plus, I can show a working solution using command-line outputs.

2.1.1 Traceroute Verification

The first clear indication of IPSec tunnel success came from a traceroute test. We ran this test from (HQ-PC1) and aimed it at the Branch Office gateway (BO-FW-EX). The `traceroute` showed that packets were being routed correctly through the encrypted tunnel. It also bypassed the ISP router, confirming that the tunnel was active and functioning properly.

Note: This live routing result helped resolve confusion caused by earlier simulator issues. It confirmed the IPSec tunnel was working.



2.1.2 Validation via Show Crypto Commands

Next, I ran the following CLI commands on both the Headquarters and Branch Office firewalls:

- `show crypto isakmp sa`
- `show crypto ipsec sa`

Headquarters Firewall (HQ-FW-EX) Results

- Outgoing traffic was encrypted.
- The tunnel status is **ACTIVE**.
- The matching transform sets and SPI values were confirmed.

Branch Office Firewall (BO-FW-EX) Results

- The inbound traffic was decrypted properly.
- The packet counters indicated that traffic was being received and processed securely.
- Security Associations (SAs) matched the output of the Headquarters firewall.

Note: Both firewalls showed nearly identical counters, matching settings, and active tunnel status, confirming that full end-HQ-end encryption and decryption were functioning.

Engineer's Insight: By verifying the **security association (SA)** status as `QM_IDLE`, I confirmed that Phase 1 was successfully negotiated, and that the tunnel was ready for data transit.

Final Reflection

This project demonstrated the importance of testing a network setup using multiple tools. Even in a lab with limited features, I was able to confirm VPN functionality using simple commands and step-by-step checks. Using traceroute to test packet flow and then checking the encryption status with `show crypto` provided strong evidence that the tunnel worked.

Takeaway: Don't depend on just one method. Use both command-line checks and live network testing together to ensure that your IPSec tunnel is up and running.